

Saint John Chrysostom
Commentary on Psalm 150

ON PSALM 150

Praise God in his saints. Another, in his holy place. Another, In his sanctified one.

Either here he speaks of the people, or of a holy life and of holy men. But see how he again concludes the book with thanksgiving, teaching us that this should be the beginning and end of what we do and say. And therefore Paul says: Whatever you do in word or deed, always give thanks to God and the Father through him (Colossians 3:17). So also the preface of our prayer begins from here. For to say Our Father is the part of those who give thanks for the gifts they have received, and they show them all by this name. For he who said Father confessed the adoption of sons: and he who confessed adoption proclaimed justice, sanctification, redemption, the remission of sins, and the supply of the Holy Spirit. For all these things must have existed before, that we may thus enjoy the adoption of sons, and be deemed worthy of calling him Father. But it seems to me that he also indicates something else, saying: In his saints, that is, through his saints. Give thanks, therefore, that he has introduced such a form of living into life, or even made men angels. And therefore, when he had first said, In the saints, he added: Praise him in the firmament of his power: indicating what I have already said. For this is more important to God than that. For heaven was made for man, not man for heaven. But another, for what is, In the firmament, said, Indelible. Another, In the firmament of his empire.

Moreover, it seems to me that he also signifies something else, as in the previous Psalm. For as he says there, Praise him, his angels: so also he says here, Praise him in his firmament (Psalm 148:2): that is, You who are in his firmament. For he does not cease continually to assume the heavenly powers also as partners in praise. Praise him in his virtues. Another, By his powers. But the Hebrew says, Begeburothau. This is what he says: Praise him for his strength, for his power, for his miracles, for the virtue which he shows through all things, which are below, which are above, which are done in common, and which are done privately, which are singly, and which are perpetual. Praise him according to the multitude of his greatness. And how can it be that he should send forth praise which corresponds to the multitude of his greatness? He does not say praise that corresponds, but, "How much," he says, "can you comprehend in your mind the multitude of his greatness, offer so much and such an offering: as much as is granted to you, such as it is fitting for a man to offer to the great God and above measure great: for no one can offer a worthy offering. Have you seen the desire of the soul? Have you seen the inflamed mind, which urges, invites, and strives, so that it may overcome its own weakness, and thereafter fly up to heaven itself, which is bound to God, and devoted to him with great desire? Praise him with the sound of the trumpet. Another, By the sound of the horn. Praise him with the psalter and harp. Another, By the lute and lyre. Praise him with the timbrel and choir; praise him with strings and organ. Another, By the strings of the harp. Praise him with well-sounding cymbals; Praise him with cymbals of jubilation. Another, With cymbals of signification. Let every spirit praise the Lord. Another, Breath. He sets all instruments in motion,

and commands that through all things melody be offered to God, kindling and exciting their souls.

Our members praise God; why musical instruments were permitted to the Jews; praise of God is the sacrifice most acceptable to him. Just as, therefore, the Jews were commanded to praise God with all instruments: so we are commanded to praise God with all our members, with the eyes, with the tongue, with the ears, and with the hands. Which indeed Paul also means when he says: Present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy, pleasing to God, which is your reasonable service (Romans 12:1). For the eye praises when it does not look shamelessly: and the tongue when it sings psalms: and the ear when it does not receive wicked songs or accusations against its neighbor: and the mind when it does not devise deceits, but is full of charity: and the feet when they do not run into vice, but to do good things: and the hands when they are not extended to theft and robbery, nor to striking and beating, but to alms, and to defending those who are injured. For then man becomes a many-stringed harp, offering many and spiritual melodies to God. Now those instruments were then permitted to them, both because of their weakness, and because they would temper them in charity and concord, and turn the mind to useful things: and because through such delight of the soul he wished to lead them to greater zeal. For when God understood how uncultivated, sluggish, and careless they were, he wished to arouse them in this way, tempering the labor and assiduity of their attendance with delightful melody. But what is, with cymbals of signification? He says this of the Psalms. For they did not beat the cymbal rashly, nor did they sound the harp rashly, but as far as it was possible, by cymbals, by trumpets, and by harps they

showed the meaning of the psalms: and the labor and zeal which they devoted to these things brought them great benefit. Let every spirit praise the Lord. For after he has called those who are in heaven, after he has stirred up the people, after he has moved all the instruments, he then goes forth to every nature, calling every age to melody, old men, men, young men, children, women, and all who dwell on the earth, from this place already casting the seeds of the New Testament for those who are spread throughout the whole earth. Let us therefore praise God continually, and let us not cease to give thanks for all things, both in words and in deeds. For this is our sacrifice and offering; this is the best ministry, which befits the angelic way of life. And if we continue to praise God in this way, we shall both pass through the present life without any offense and obtain the good things to come: which may it be granted to us all to obtain, through the grace and mercies of our Lord Jesus Christ, with whom be glory, honor, and dominion to the Father with the Holy Spirit, now and ever, and unto the ages of ages. Amen.